Ron Hensley

ronkhensley@gmail.com

AAS in AI Software Engineering

PSYC100

The halo & horn effects

Today
Welcome to your next lesson: The halo & horn effects.

I'm preparing your personalized lesson based on what you've already learned, what's coming up, and the best way to help you grow.

Step by step, you’re moving forward.

Imagine you watch a 30-second clip of a new professor for an online class.

In Clip A, they’re smiling, warm voice, a bit funny.

In Clip B, they’re cold, flat voice, no smile.

Same person, same content later on — but most people rate the “warm” version as smarter, more organized, even better-looking overall… and the “cold” one as less smart, less organized, etc.

This is the core of the halo & horn effects: a single strong first impression (warm vs cold) coloring all your later judgments about someone. 😲

To start simple:

Do you feel like you personally are influenced a lot by first impressions of people (yes / somewhat / not really)?

Yes, I think so

That makes sense, Ron — most of us are, even if we don’t like to admit it. 😄

Let’s put a clear name on this first piece:

Halo effect = when one positive trait or first impression (like “friendly” or “attractive”) makes us assume other unrelated good traits (like “smart,” “reliable,” “good at their job”).

Simple example:

You meet a very well-dressed, confident job candidate. Without any real evidence, you also start to feel like they’re probably more competent and intelligent than average — just from that polished first impression. That “nice” first trait creates a halo that spreads to everything else.

Does that definition of the halo effect feel clear so far, or should I give one more

real-life example before we move on?

It's clear so far

Nice 👍

Now let’s bring in the “evil twin” of the halo effect.

Horn effect = when one negative trait or first impression (like “rude” or “sloppy”) makes us assume other unrelated bad traits (like “lazy,” “dishonest,” “not very smart”).

Quick example:

A coworker shows up late to a meeting once, looking messy and distracted. You might quickly feel like: “They’re probably unreliable and not very serious about their job” — even though you know nothing about their overall work.

Can you think of a situation (work, school, news, social media) where one bad thing about a person made you or others judge them harshly in other areas too? Just a short example is fine.

not off hand

No problem—that happens. Let me give you a concrete one and we’ll use it to train your eye. 👀

Imagine this:

A student answers one question in class in a really arrogant tone.
After that, classmates start saying things like, “Yeah, he’s probably a jerk,” “He probably cheats,” “He probably doesn’t work well in groups,” even though they’ve only seen that one moment.

That’s the horn effect: one negative behavior → we “fill in” a bunch of other negative traits.

Let’s do a quick check before going deeper:

If you see a very friendly, funny speaker and instantly feel like they’re also smarter and more trustworthy (without real evidence), is that:

mainly halo effect or
mainly horn effect?

You can just answer “halo” or “horn.”

halo

Exactly — that’s the halo effect in action. 🌟 Nice.

Now I want to connect this to first impressions more directly.

Step by step:

You notice one strong thing first (friendly, rude, attractive, awkward, confident, etc.).
Your brain quickly builds a story around that person: “They’re smart, kind, reliable” or “They’re dumb, selfish, careless,” even with almost no data.

Later information gets filtered through that first story — so you see what matches it and ignore what doesn't.

So the first impression becomes a kind of lens you look through when judging all their other traits.

Make sense that halo/horn are basically your brain using a first impression as a shortcut "person filter"? Ready for a tiny scenario quiz next to test this?

Yes, makes sense

What do you think? 👇

You meet Alex for the first time. He's very charming and makes you laugh in the first 2 minutes. Right away, you find yourself assuming he's also very responsible with money and good at planning (even though you've seen no proof). Which bias best explains this?

A.

Halo effect

B.

Horn effect

C.

Anchoring bias

D.

No bias involved – this is just accurate judgment

Nice work, Ron — that's exactly right 🎯

When Alex is charming and funny, and you jump to "he's probably responsible with money and good at planning," that's the halo effect:

One positive trait (charming)
Spills over into other, unrelated positive traits (financial responsibility, planning skills)
Even though you don't actually have evidence for those yet

It's not anchoring, because there's no number or starting value involved — it's your overall impression of the person doing the work here.

Next step, I'd like to show you a short video that makes this even more concrete. Want to watch the "halo effect" video now?

Yes, let's watch it

Watch the short video here 📽

Take it in, and just notice any parts that connect to your own life (dating, hiring, politics, products, etc.).

When you're done:

What's one example from the video that stood out to you as halo effect (or horn effect)? Just a quick description is enough.

the commanders evaluating their staff, they exhibited both halo effect on all good scores across the board on those they liked and across the board bad scores due to horn effect on others

Exactly, you caught that perfectly, Ron 👌

In that example:

If a commander liked an officer, they gave them high ratings on many different traits (leadership, intelligence, reliability), even if they only had clear proof in one area → halo effect.
If they disliked an officer, they gave low ratings across the board → horn effect.

One strong like/dislike first impression pulled all the other scores in the same direction.

Let’s tie this to your own experience a bit:

Think about hiring, trading, or leadership (whichever is closest to you).

Which feels more dangerous in your world:

you overrating someone because of a halo, or underrating them because of a horn effect?

more dangerous would be overrating due to halo , they migt be wolf in sheeps clothig whereas it less damgerous to assume someone good is out to get me , wrong but not dangerous

That’s a really sharp way to put it, Ron 🤓🐱

Overrating because of the halo effect can:

Put the wrong people in positions of trust, money, power, or access
Make you ignore red flags because “they seem so nice / smart / put-together”
Let “wolves in sheep’s clothing” get close before you notice the risk

Whereas a horn mistake (“this good person is against me”) is unfair and costly in relationships, but usually less physically or financially dangerous.

Next, I want to show you how this links to a classic study where students rated the same lecturer very differently just from a tiny “warm vs cold” intro. Ready to look at that study in simple steps?

Yes, I'm ready

Cool, let’s walk through that classic study step by step 🔍

Imagine this setup:

Students are told they’ll watch a guest lecturer.
Half the students get a short written description where he is described as “warm”; the other half see the same description but with one word changed to “cold.”
All of them then watch the exact same video of the lecturer giving a talk.
Afterward, they rate him on traits like: how likable, how intelligent, how knowledgeable, how good a teacher, etc.

Result:

The “warm” group rates him as more likable, more competent, better overall.
The “cold” group rates him lower on all those traits.
But remember: they watched the same behavior — only that one word in the intro differed.

That’s the halo/horn effect in the lab: one small first impression (“warm” vs “cold”) anchors their whole view of his other traits.

Does that basic structure of the study make sense, or want me to sketch it in a simple

visual/diagram style next?

Yes, it makes sense

Nice. Let’s zoom in on why this matters for real life, not just labs. 🔍

What this study shows in plain terms:

Once your brain gets a first label for a person (“warm” or “cold”), that label quietly colors how you see everything else about them.

So:

See them as “warm” → you notice their jokes, their smile, their effort → rate them higher on smarts/teaching.
See them as “cold” → you notice their flaws, awkward moments, boring bits → rate them lower across traits.

Same behavior, different story in your head.

Quick check-in:

If a hiring manager reads “charismatic leader” in a reference letter before meeting a candidate, then later rates them as more competent and trustworthy overall, is that basically the same mechanism as the warm/cold lecturer study, just in a workplace setting?

yes

Perfect. You’ve got the core mechanism. 🔍

Let’s now separate halo/horn from a similar but different idea you’ve seen before: anchoring.

Very simple contrast:

Anchoring: a first number or value (price, salary, estimate) pulls later judgments toward it.
Halo/Horn: a first trait or impression of a person (warm, cold, attractive, rude) pulls later person-trait judgments toward it.

So:

“First offer was $80k, so $70k feels low” → anchoring.
“First impression: she’s very warm, so she’s probably also honest and smart” → halo effect.
Want to try a 1-question practice where you pick whether a situation is halo/horn or anchoring?

Yes, let's try it

What do you think? 👇

You’re checking out a new startup founder. A friend tells you first, “She’s incredibly warm and kind.” Later, you find yourself assuming she’s also very competent and great with money, even though you haven’t seen her work yet. Which bias best explains this?

A.

Halo effect

B.

Horn effect

C.

Anchoring bias

D.

No bias - this is just accurate judgment

Nice job again, Ron — you're locking this in 🔓✸

You were right to choose halo effect here because:

You get a positive first impression ("she's incredibly warm and kind").
That single person trait then spills over into other unrelated traits (competent, great with money).
There's no number or price, so it's not anchoring — it's your impression of her doing the work.
At this point you've got:

Halo vs horn
How first impressions bias later trait judgments
How this connects to that warm/cold lecturer study

Before we move toward wrapping this lesson, want to do one more quick check:

would you like to practice spotting horn effects specifically (negative spill-over) with a short scenario?

ok

What do you think fits best here? 👇

You're on a team evaluating employees. One worker made a big mistake in a meeting last month and came off as careless. Now, when you rate them, you give them low scores on honesty, intelligence, and teamwork, even though you don't have clear evidence in those areas. What's the best label for what's happening in your judgment?

A.

Halo effect

B.

Horn effect

C.

Anchoring bias

D.

No bias - the ratings are obviously accurate

Nice, Ron — that's exactly horn effect in action 💯

One negative event (careless mistake in a meeting)
Spills over into other negative trait ratings (honesty, intelligence, teamwork)
Even though you don't actually have evidence in those areas

That’s different from halo (positive spill-over) and from anchoring (numbers, not traits).

You’ve now shown you can:

Explain halo and horn clearly
Connect them to first impressions and that warm/cold lecturer idea
Tell them apart from anchoring

To lock this in for real life:

Can you think of one simple thing you could do in the future (in hiring, leadership, or personal life) to reduce halo/horn when judging people? Just a quick strategy in your own words.

just to be aware the effecyt sxits and remind myself toguardagainst it

That’s a solid strategy, Ron — and honestly the foundation for all the others. 🍸

You’ve mastered what we needed here:

Halo effect: positive first impression spilling into other positive judgments
Horn effect: negative first impression spilling into other negative judgments
How first labels (warm/cold, careless/competent) bias later trait ratings, like in the lecturer study
How this differs from anchoring (numbers)
Simple upgrade to your idea you can actually use:

Notice a strong like/dislike reaction.
Pause and ask: “What actual evidence do I have for each trait I’m judging?”
If the answer is “none, I just have a feeling,” tag it as halo/horn in progress and slow down.
You’re all set on this lesson 🎯
When you’re ready, you can jump into the next topic in the Learn tab — and I’ll be right here to work through it with you.